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Complex Worker: Self-Concept and Boundary-Work Among the Solo Self-Employed

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ABSTRACT

This article proposes to examine the self-concept of members of an occupational category referred to as the “solo self-employed”—women and men who work alone and do not employ other workers. Our findings reveal that although the solo self-employed themselves do not make clear phenomenological use of the solo-self-employed category, they do speak similarly about their occupational independence, albeit without group awareness. The self-concept of the solo self-employed is mainly based on boundary work in relation to two well-known cultural-occupational categories: “employed workers” and “businesspeople.” Solo-employed workers prefer to distance themselves from these two categories and define themselves through negative comparisons between themselves and the two preceding categories. The Discussion section proposes perceiving solo self-employment as a social category that constructs an alternative self in relation to the selves associated with popular cultural-occupational scenarios.

Introduction

This article proposes to examine the self-concept (Callero 2003) of members of an occupational category called “solo self-employed,” that is, women and men who work alone and do not employ any workers. This research examination is important in light of the prevalent descriptions of the current characteristics of occupational life under capitalism and neoliberalism (Boltanski and Chiapello 2005), which are expressed, inter alia, by a high degree of risk (Beck 2000), flexibility (Bauman 1993), instability, and promotion of an entrepreneurial self (Brockling 2016). In addition, an examination of the self-concept of solo self-employed is important in light of a number of current descriptions: 50% of businesses in the Western world (Van Stel, Sander, and Gerard 2012) are solo self-employed, which is about 6% of the entire working population (The Ministry of Finance 2013); reports of stable data indicating a high percentage of failures (about 75%), that is, the closure of small independent businesses in the first years because of the difficulties in realizing occupational independence (Pepperman 2009); the economic forecasts that more and more people in Western cultures will work in part-time jobs (Dixon, McCollum, and Fullerton 2018) as self-employed persons and business owners (Heilman and Chen 2003); the ambiguity of the “self-employed” category (and of “solo self-employed” in particular); and the use of a long series of concepts between which there is no precise distinction, including entrepreneur, large business, small business, portfolio worker, freelance, work from home, and VAT-exempt dealer (Heilman and Chen 2003; Wennekers et al. 2010).

Government authorities that have a direct connection with independent workers, as institutions that receive taxes from them, reinforce this categorical ambiguity. This ambiguity is expressed by the different names given to independent workers by government institutions

(VAT, the IRS, and Social Security). But mainly, it is the homogenous grouping of all of the independent workers underneath one identity-umbrella: “business” or “entrepreneur.” This broad identity includes independent workers who work from home and make \$1,000 a month, as well as business owners who employ 100 workers and bring in earnings of \$40 million a year. This unification exists even though 63% of independent workers are solo self-employed, while another 30% employ one or two other workers (see sba.economy.gov.il). In addition, 90% of the independent workers in Israel, for example, are not entrepreneurs and do not create jobs, and the connection between them and big business owners is purely administrative. In other words, the independent category mainly exists in the world of taxation but is not a recognized sociological or political-economic category (Swirasky and Ofir 2014). Against this background the phenomenology of the solo self-employed is very important.

Four main research questions lie at the foundation of this article: What are the self-understandings (self-concept) of the solo self-employed? What characterizes their employment career? How do solo self-employed define and experience occupational independence? What are the relationships between the self-concept of the solo self-employed and the cultural-occupational discourse prevalent in contemporary culture?

Our research offers two unique theoretical and empirical contributions to the self-concept of solo self-employed and to the connection between self-concept and specific orders of discourse. Our research includes a phenomenological examination of a specific population included in the self-employed category: professional, educated, ages 29–45, engaging in jobs of the upper middle class (e.g. clinical psychologist, jewelry designer, lawyer, animator, magician, architect, and curator).

The current research literature primarily offers descriptions about the self-employed in high-tech fields (Barley and Kunda 2004), the self-employed in low socioeconomic jobs (Essers and Benschope 2009), and coaches (George 2013). Our main findings reveal unique dynamics in this context. Although solo self-employed do not make phenomenological use of the category “solo self-employed,” they speak similarly of their occupational independence even without group consciousness. Moreover, solo self-employed individuals have a well-defined occupational identity, did not plan to be self-employed, and worked well as employees but do not wish to return to salaried work. The choice of independence is depicted as slow and calculated and related to the desire for a “sufficient” salary rather than profits (as opposed, e.g., to the high-tech self-employed in Barley and Kunda’s 2004 study). Moreover, the self-concept of the solo self-employed is based on boundary work in relation to two familiar cultural or “socially strong” categories: salaried employees, on one hand, and businessmen and entrepreneurs, on the other. The solo self-employed is described as a life alternative, which constitutes an alternative self in relation to the self that is affiliated with the cultural-occupational scenarios of the upper middle class that emphasize competitiveness, achievement, consumer accumulation of resources, and hyperindividualism (Stephens, Markus, and Phillips 2014).

The second research contribution of this article emphasizes the relationship between a specific private self-concept and broad orders of cultural discourse. Our interviewees seek to dissociate themselves from the “extreme” versions of the capitalist and neoliberal discourse (Boltanski and Chiapello 2005) and creatively construct an occupational category that creates and reinforces their personal self-concept. This creative construction and the negotiations with broad orders of discourse, which are phenomenologically described as limiting the individual agency, deserve research attention, as this article suggests.

Self-concept, orders of discourse, and employment

The prevailing definitions of the self-concept emphasize the manner in which individuals experience themselves, act on themselves, and interact with the social structure in which they are

immersed (Elliot 2001). This same configuration is often perceived as an inner-private domain of thoughts, emotions, passions, and personal values through which we explain our lifestyle, shape our bodies, consume goods, signify tastes, and briefly express our uniqueness (Rose 1996). Our principal assumption, in the wake of poststructuralism, is that the self-concepts exist within and not outside the discourse and therefore must be understood as being produced in specific historical and institutional sites and through discursive practices (Hall 1996). At the same time, as Foucault (1988) identified, it is not enough to describe what is prevalent in the literature on how discourse types and power sites imply details, but we also need to expand our understanding of the array of responses of individuals to different orders of discourse. Cushman (1995), in the wake of Foucault, described, for example, how capitalism establishes a specific configuration of the self, which he called the “empty self,” which in turn strengthens the capitalist rationales. These rationalizations promote a phenomenology of “inadequacy” and “emptiness” and a reflexivity of “chronic fulfillment” through consumption (which is often enabled in the credit framework offered by the banking system) of products, treatments, and lifestyles. Moreover, Cushman (1995), like other scholars (Illouz 2008), portrayed how this self is maintained through discursive alliances (Shoshana 2014) with the psychological discourse and the neoliberal discourse.

The neoliberal discourse (Harvey 2005) and the capitalist discourse (the “traditional” and the “current” (see Boltanski and Chiapello 2005) are not only economic or political. These discourses also encourage psychological experiences of individuals in daily life (Shoshana 2014). These discourses promote cultural values of productive work ethic, autonomy, choice, competitive individualism, self-responsibility, entrepreneurship, self-control, self-reliance, and, in short, homo-economicus.

The employment field can teach us about this connection between orders of discourse and self-concepts in everyday life, expressed, *inter alia*, by the creative invention of occupational categories in the spirit of the entrepreneurial self (Brockling 2016), such as self-employed in high-tech (Barley and Kunda 2004), and coaches (George 2013). Since the late 1970s, the world of employment has undergone great changes. Two hundred years of dominance of the industrial age began to dissolve in the face of the many changes that have taken place in the world, led by globalization processes, the information technology revolution (Baines 2002), and the strengthening of the services sector (Beck 2000). One of the outcomes of these changes is the constant trend of opening businesses in many modern economies, especially those of the self-employed and small businesses. This trend is often referred to as the “Second Industrial Revolution” and “Renaissance” (Heilman and Chen 2003).

These changes also influence people’s career perception in recent decades. The classic career pattern (Weber 1981), in which man progresses by moving upward, in terms of salary and function, as part of an organizational hierarchy, is diminishing (Barley and Kunda 2004). One of the prominent spokespersons of this trend is Charles Henry, who had already claimed in the early 1980s that one of the most important social revolutions that took place was the transition from an organized work life to a world in which we would have to worry about our future independently. He indicated that the world was becoming more competitive, and the relationship between institutions and individuals weakened; thus, concepts such as “job security” “in it for life” will lose their cultural ambience (Handy 1984).

Self-employed individuals who work alone, similar to self-employed individuals with employees, also have many names: “self-employed,” “small-business owners,” “people who work from home,” “freelancers,” “portfolio workers,” “self-employed individuals,” “independent tax-payers,” “individuals exempt from taxes,” and “solo self-employed,” among others. However, in contrast to “self-employed,” which is a recognized category, the solo self-employed have not been recognized through research as a group, even though they represent 50% of all workers in the Western world (Van Stel et al. 2012). In fact, this is considered quite a weak category (Wildhagen 2015), one almost nonexistent in daily discussions.

To identify the basic differences between the various groups of self-employed workers, Boegenhold and Fachinger (2012) conducted comprehensive analyses on data from a national German database, a country with a large percentage of solo self-employed. They created an internal division between self-employed individuals who employ other workers and solo self-employed individuals. Each of these groups was further divided into men and women, and then again divided into four sectors—industry, services, local trade, and agriculture. Then an additional division was created—full-time versus part-time self-employed workers. The study found, as other previous studies reported (Van Stel et al. 2012), that most of the solo self-employed are in the services sector and that it is less common to find solo self-employed individuals in other fields, such as industry, agriculture, and local commerce. In regard to age, they found that solo self-employed workers are younger on average than self-employed individuals who employ other workers. More women than men are solo self-employed. Regarding education, except for certain fields, the more educated self-employed individuals are those who employ other workers (Bogenhold and Fachinger 2012).

Additional quantitative studies have tried to characterize the economic contribution of the solo self-employed. A report from 2010 shows that many solo self-employed workers are only slightly more financially rewarded than employed workers; that is, they earn a similar salary to what they would earn if they were employed by others (Wennekers et al. 2010). Van Stel et al. (2012) claim that despite interpersonal variances, which certainly exist in the group, there are many similar characteristics among group members, including their motivations for opening their businesses. In addition, their economic contributions are considered similar within the group, and different from those of self-employed individuals who employ others.

It is important to note that the existing studies differentiate between (1) solo self-employed workers who have “strong” professional and occupational identities and (2) “new” solo self-employed workers who don’t necessarily have consolidated professional identities. This category relates to semiprofessionals, such as life coaches, interior designers, alternative medicine therapists, cosmeticians, photographers, editors, fitness trainers, and various types of consultants. This group may be referred to as expert service workers, a large percentage of whom are women. George (2013) researched the professional development of life coaches in the market as an example of a predominantly solo self-employed group that tries to define itself as a profession and themselves as professionals. George’s study findings show the complex strategies these workers employed to achieve professional recognition for their work. To achieve this end, for example, they compared themselves to more professional occupations. As soon as their professional identities were clear, they tried to guarantee institutional support by organizing their knowledge, training, and practice; at the same time, they related to the idea of their “natural talents” and life experiences as the most significant parts of their professions (George 2013).

Therefore, an analysis of the research literature about the solo self-employed shows a statistical interest (e.g., between the economic measures of a country and the number of solo self-employed) in this sector, the relative lack of research studies about solo self-employed workers (Barley and Kunda 2004), the dramatic changes occurring over the past decades in the work world, and the dramatic percentage of failure to structurally support the solo self-employed (Pepperman 2009). These characteristics provide a strong need for a deeper phenomenological understanding of this group. But first we describe the study design overview upon which our article is based.

Study design

This article is based on in-depth interviews with 30 subjects—15 men and 15 women. The age range was 29 to 45, and the average age was 37. The interviews were conducted between August 2014 and December 2018. The interview sample was a purposeful sample (Berg 1998), including representation of a wide range of professions, regions throughout Israel, and demographic

Table 1. Interviewees' variables distribution.

Variables	%
Gender	
Male	50
Female	50
Age	
29–34	20
35–40	45
40–45	35
Marital status	
Married	75 ^a
Single	15
Divorced	10
Solo self-employed seniority (in years)	
1–2	30
3–5	45
6–7	10
8–10	15
Place of work	
Home	75
Office/Clinic	25

^aSpouse's type of employment among married couples: 86% employed; 14% self-employed.

characteristics. We chose not to interview more than two subjects from each profession or a closely related professional field. The following is a description of the criteria defining the solo self-employed.

Solo self-employed criteria

1. Self-employed business owners, registered as such with the authorities for one year or more.
2. People with medium-high education levels—all of the interviewees in the study had a certain level of education: one year or more of certified study in their professions, studies including one or more academic degrees, all of the professions reflected medium-high levels of prestige. The differentiation of self-employed individuals by education level also appears in prior studies (Moore and Buttner 1997). The interviewees' professions were as follows: two curators, programmer, two animators, two tour guides, two clinical psychologists, two magician, lawyer, two jewelry designers, two architects, software consultant, two interior designers, two advertising consultants, two international trade salesperson, two graphic artist, organic farm owner, boutique perfume creator, decorative metalworker, social initiative creator, and a seamstress who makes ornamental items.
3. Solo self-employed who don't earn money through a permanent contract with any type of organization that provides their income; solo self-employed who must market themselves to acquire clients.
4. Age range from 29 to 45: The age of the individual was found to be related to career factors such as ambitions to advance one's career, planning for career advancement, work commitment, and more (Morrow and McElroy 1987). The 20 to 40 age range relates to the first stage of the person's career. In this stage, the individual develops a self-identity in the work world, strives to realize professional goals, and experiences a deep commitment to her or his work (Morrow and McElroy 1987).
5. Solo self-employed workers whose main job is that of a self-employed worker and who don't simultaneously work as employees for other companies.

Table 1 describes the variables distribution of the interviewees.

Interviews

The interviews were carried out through sending e-mails to a mailing list of work colleagues, friends, and acquaintances explaining the study subject and defining the requirements of the interview study population. In this e-mail we also requested each participant to find three solo self-employed individuals from their various professional fields. In the event that the individuals fulfilled the criteria, interviews were set up with them. Each interview was 90 minutes in length and conducted in the participants' homes, except for two cases in which the interviews were conducted in a quiet coffee shop at the request of these two interviewees.

The interviews comprised eight main parts: a general question ("Tell me about yourself in the professional context"), professional life history ("Where did you work previously?"), occupational self-definition ("How do you define yourself?"), work routine ("Describe a typical workday"), professional identity ("What is the nature of your job?"), the transition to independence ("When and how did this transition take place?"), advantages and disadvantages of being a solo self-employed worker, and future work plans.

An analysis of the interviews was carried out in accordance with the procedure proposed by the grounded theory (Strauss and Corbin 1998). Against this background, seven main focused readings of the interviews were carried out: general definitions of the term *self-employed* (self-conception), professional self-definition (professional and occupational identity), the transition to independence, work routine, the solo self-employed experience in regard to one's general self-image, boundary work, and the alternative self. The last two readings are a product of inductive exposure following previous readings.

Occupational definitions, weak and strong categories

The research findings show that the interviewees' work-related definitions of independence are varied and multifaceted. Most did not use the term *independent* but chose other words to describe their status. Moreover, the expression *solo self-employed* did not come up at all.¹ This shows the weakness of the category as opposed to strong or socially recognized categories (such as "employed" or "businesspeople/entrepreneurs"). Shiran, who has been a solo self-employed worker for three years, describes her difficulty in defining her work, to both herself and the surrounding environment:

I remember someone asking me what I did and I said I had a gold jewelry design business, and then a friend said: "Why do you put it like that? Say you're a jewelry designer—it sounds much better." Suddenly, I said: "Wait a minute, am I a jewelry designer or do I have a jewelry design business?" ... [and what's the difference?] ... *a jewelry designer* means that I only design jewelry. *Having a business* means I do everything ... I manage everything. From my point of view, I have a jewelry design business.

In contrast to Shiran, Galit determinedly uses the term *business* and emphasizes her distance from a category that is considered "low" in her eyes (*freelance*):

I say that I'm a consultant for advertising agents. In my opinion, it's a business. Totally. It's not just something I do to pass the time. It's how I make my living. It's a service people need and I see the value I

¹It is important to note that respondents may not identify with the category of solo self-employed not because they are not aware of it but because it does not actually exist. In other words, in the spirit of the descriptions of Foucault (1988) and Hacking (1986), social categories are the inventions of experts, officials, or countries that express the management of populations or reality in a "top-down" manner. This reality is not necessarily familiar or internalized by "everyday people" and does not receive phenomenological support from the "bottom up" (see Shoshana 2012, 2016 in this context).

provide ... I hate when someone says I'm a freelancer. It sounds inferior, low. Someone who is useful for only a few hours; there's something very performance-related about it. That's really not me. I always correct people, and say it's my business.

Most of the interviews showed that the majority of interviewees were not aware of being part of a group or belonging to a certain category, and when, at the end of the interview, we shared some of our research findings with them, they showed great interest. Daniella said:

I know from experience that I don't fall into any category, but from what you describe it sounds as if there are others like me and I very much like the idea that I am part of a group; I don't feel like I am. But suddenly, I understand, like an imaginary community, that there is a kind of community like this. That somewhere out there, there are actually people who experience the same things; feel the same way. I never saw it like that because I'm so busy with my own thing. It's a group that doesn't even have a name. What is it? It's strange.

The solo self-employed define themselves in different ways; are not aware that they compose a group; and oppose "belittling" categories like "working from home," "project-based workers," or "freelancers." At the same time, most do not define themselves as self-employed and definitely not as entrepreneurs, small-business owners, or businesspeople. In addition to distancing themselves from these concepts, they also distance themselves from the term *employed*; it is clear to them that they "are not employed workers" and that this is a solid category connected to their past. The most common term used among the self-employed in the interviews was "business," without reference to size or accompanying words, and always to represent one's basic occupational identity—the profession.

While the identity of the self-employed or solo self-employed remains unclear, the occupational identity centered around the profession chosen by the interviewees is unanimous and clear among this group. All of the interviewees, with no exceptions, say they love their work and have a stable occupational identity, full of passion and enthusiasm.² This point really stood out in the interviews, as is clear from the following examples:

Yaron: I have the best job in the world (guide). The best. The most fun, great money, the most interesting, and I'm constantly meeting new people on a weekly basis.

Lior: It's the best job in the world (magician); nothing could be better. It's a kind of vocation; you make people happy ... create exhilarating experiences.

It appears that the occupational identity of the interviewees has two aspects—the basic occupational identity, which is whole and stable, and the solo self-employed or business identity, which is blurry and lacks a concrete category. In light of the enthusiastic occupational identities of the solo self-employed, together with the complexity of self-definitions, the question arises: What motivated them to become self-employed?

The period of being employed by others: managing and succeeding within a framework

The popular cultural scenario describing the self-employed is that this type of independence is unstable in nature and involves risk-taking as well as an unstable income. All of this is also apparently connected to impulsivity and a difficulty to accept authority (Harris, Saltstone, and Fraboni 1999). In complete contrast, however, most of our interviewees reported that they were employed workers for many years and managed very well. Some were very successful employed workers, enjoyed good relationships with their bosses and colleagues, as well as the benefits of being employed by others. Many of them did long stints in the army (mandatory in Israel),

²It is important to note in this context that we do not claim that enthusiasm for professional identity also implies enthusiasm for the solo self-employed category. This analytic caution is also required in light of the fact that our interviewees work in various professions. We thank one of the anonymous readers for this distinction.

engaged in long periods of study, and encountered frameworks where they spent several stable and productive years as employed workers. Naomi describe her excellent relations within her former workplaces:

I don't have a problem being employed by others; I'm good with organizations. I also managed very well in the Army and was an officer. I have something—good inter-personal relations skills—that breaks down opposition. I think that in an organization, I would advance quickly, if that's what I really wanted.

In fact, only four interviewees (out of 30) said that they had a hard time managing in frameworks, and bore any resemblance to the popular image of the self-employed individual. Thus, our findings show that independence is a choice, rather than something one is forced to do (Still and Walker 2006), at least among the solo self-employed, mid-to-high socioeconomic status participants in our study.

Signs of discomfort

Although most of the self-employed managed well in frameworks over time, at some stage, they became restless as employed workers, which no longer suited their self-concepts. The “norms of the ideal employee” (Williams 2000) no longer fit, and they began to feel a sense of discomfort opposite this model and its implications. All of the interviewees mentioned that the years connected to the transition period and the changes related to becoming self-employed were full of thoughts, doubts, and even crises—out of which the decision to become independent was born.

The interviewees spoke about the transition as a process and, rather than mentioning specific reasons, they described, in most of the cases, a slow realization of events that led to the decision. An analysis of the interviews revealed five sources of discomfort relating to the ideal worker scenario: limited self-expression, slow and unrealistic economic development, disgust with organizational politics, discomfort connected to turning 40, and pregnancy and giving birth. To illustrate this empirically, we discuss the first two sources.

Limited self-expression

Some of the interviewees described feelings of frustration while being employed because of a lack of occupational self-expression and the feeling that they needed to do things at work that they didn't feel were right, despite their connection to the profession itself or the workplace. This finding may reinforce the statistical finding of Still and Walker's (2006) study, in which 41% of self-employed women said that they became independent because they wanted to be more creative. Both the men and women in our study touched upon this theme.

Naomi tried several work models as an architect before becoming independent and succeeded in all of them, but each one had its own significant disadvantages. She describes her feelings of being “second fiddle”:

I didn't feel that I needed an office to do houses and I didn't really enjoy doing larger-scale projects (commercial and public). The truth is, when you work in an office, a lot of your work isn't really about architecture. You're just a partner, but the one who really does the ground work is someone else, or the company owner. It was clear to me that I was in a place where I could do a house on my own, that I had enough experience and skill.

The interviews show that the difficulty to express oneself isn't really connected to the workplace per se. The interviewees also reported difficulty doing things they didn't think were professional.

Slow and controlled economic development

Some of the interviewees described a sense of discomfort and significant opposition in regard to their expected economic advancement as employed workers and their desire to pave new, alternative paths.

Reli is a psychologist who isn't willing to earn the salaries received by psychologists who work with public institutions. She is disgusted by the many training sessions and what she calls a "traumatic" waste of time. Regarding the economic aspect, she explains:

When I realized working in the public sector meant I'd be making NIS 30 an hour and would have to pay a babysitter NIS 40 an hour, I said: "No way." Even if I had a stronger economic base, which I didn't, it would have seemed bizarre, and unjust. Even if I wouldn't have had children [to support], it just wouldn't have felt right.

Tzach, a practical engineer and metalworker, who worked for several years as an employed worker, also discussed the economic consideration as part of what motivated him to become independent. He describes the world of employed workers—predictable and planned out in advance—as a path he does not want to take:

As an employed worker, I knew what my salary would be, my advancement in the company, everything going along as planned ... but from my point of view, I thought that from an economic perspective, I wouldn't have any problem becoming independent. That was my feeling at the time. "If I can succeed financially and also gain my independence ...," so I went for it.

Along with these feelings of discomfort, it is important to mention that all of the interviewees reported doing things gradually, slowly and carefully, in their narratives: taking on their first independent projects while still employed, working for friends, delivering invoices through others, engaging in thought processes about independence versus being employed, learning new skills and acquiring new tools before becoming self-employed, and additional practices related to taking careful and calculated steps toward independence.

Being solo self-employed: boundary-work between employed workers and businesspeople

The concept of boundary-work (Lamont 2000) attempts to examine how individuals experience their senses of self and how they produce self-worth, especially in relation to social categories and the groups they belong to and don't belong they belong to or are excluded from. Thus, boundary-work research examines which categories individuals choose to identify with and which they prefer to distance themselves from.

While descriptions of the beginning of the path to independence were paved with doing things gradually, checking, experimenting, and a lack of clarity about the path itself and knowledge about what exactly should be done, the interviewees' comments about the present are completely different. A total of 26 out of 30 of the study's interviewees were enthusiastic, whole with themselves, and determined about their "independent" lifestyle in the present while completely dismissive even of the idea of going back to being employed workers. In a few cases, this feeling was extremely intense, to the point where going back to being someone else's employee was comparable to death. In Daniella's words:

Today, I can't imagine any situation that would make me want to be an employed worker. One of the museums offered me a permanent and important position. They told me: "It's good [after getting divorced] to have a permanent income; think about it." I called them back and said: "It's not me! Not me!" To go back to those hallways, good lord, and every day is the same ... even though it's a challenging job; it's death. Simply death.

The distance they now feel from the world of being employed by others and their passion for independence are interwoven, and most of the interviewees mentioned them both in the same

sentence, skipping between the advantages of being independent and the disadvantages of being an employed worker and, refusing to ever go back to being employees. Self-employment is frequently compared to being employed by another—as if you can’t have one without the other. The next section shows how the determined attitudes of the solo self-employed are frequently maintained by the intensive boundary-work they do opposite their previously employed images of themselves. At the same time, it is worthwhile to note one space where they still choose to resemble employed workers.

Employed versus self-employed workers

Boundary-work opposite employed workers, in contrast to boundary-work opposite businesspeople, is conducted in opposition to a realistic and recognized group (from the not-too-distant past) of self-employed individuals – and a group in which most of their life partners belong. It’s important to mention that it was this boundary-work that clearly brought out the identification of “self-employed worker” among interviewees. This was the only part of the interview in which the category was present in a clearer manner.

The analysis of the findings allows us to identify five main axes through which the solo self-employed subjects compare themselves to employed workers: diversity versus restriction, free lifestyles versus a planned lifestyle, finding oneself versus corporate anonymity, professional control versus professional compromise, and convenience versus maneuvering. For empirical illustration, we focus on the first two.

Diversity versus restriction—“Doing everything”

The importance of variety and the abilities of the solo self-employed, at the heart of their independence, came up as a main and significant discovery, traits apparently lacking when one is employed in an organization. Many interviewees said they do a combination of things: programming and consultation, treatment and treatment-related research, several types of art, and so on. Keren, who was an employed worker for many years, says:

When you work in big companies, your job position is defined and you are evaluated according to it, but you need to do very specific things. They might even get angry with you if you take responsibility for something that isn’t yours. So, I’ve been inside these patterns. And then suddenly I discovered that being self-employed gives me much more freedom. That if I want to add something new to the business—it works.

The way of thinking of an employed individual, reflected in Keren’s words, is defined, contained and limited. Keren describes herself as someone who feels restricted by this type of thinking, and decides to make a change. Keren also talks about opening up the categories, about limited ways of thinking, about a diverse and creative experiencing of the self, when she compares being independent to being employed.

Keren makes frequent use of the following concepts: “everything,” “many,” “lots of,” “open”; in contrast to “boundaries,” “restriction,” and “one” when describing being an employed worker. For Yonatan, a more senior self-employed worker, diversity has become more deeply rooted and is now a way of life. Over the past several years, he has divided his time between “two part-time jobs”:

I usually do two projects at a time, so I won’t get bored. Sort of two part-time jobs at the same time. Over this past year, I’ve also been involved in a new initiative partnership, so I organize my time accordingly.

The diversity described by the solo self-employed allows for the cancelation of a hierarchy between their fields of interest. They are not required to choose, censor and minimize, but can integrate and express themselves on multiple levels.

Professional control versus professional compromise—“It is very important to me to be precise for myself”

An additional form of boundary-work was described in relation to professional choices. Being independent, in contrast to being employed, according to our interviewees, enables the individual to pick and choose her or his tasks and projects and—most important—how to carry them out. It allows the individual to do things in a proper manner, in a way that feels right to him or her; to exercise creative freedom; and to execute projects at an optimal level. According to the interviewees, this freedom of choice reinforces their enjoyment and passion, motivating their work. Concepts such as “choice” and “decision” came up in the interviews, mainly in the professional context. Meital emphasizes this point:

In my opinion, self-employed people love what they do because they choose it. Within the profession itself, they also have more freedom of choice regarding which works to take and which to turn away.

Daniella stresses the need to “do things right”:

First of all, the feeling that I control my own agenda is very important. That I decide what I do and what I don’t do. I make the rules. It’s very important to me to be precise for myself. To do what’s interesting and right for me at the moment.

It is important to stress that boundary-work in opposition to employed work reveals motivations that, in most cases, were unknown to solo self-employed workers and were discovered only through experience. Besides all of their descriptions about the importance of “the not [externally] employed self,” one thing was clear: The financial aspect was the one aspect in which solo self-employed wanted to resemble employed workers. This finding supports economists who claim that the solo self-employed contribute to the economy and are similar in this way to employed workers (Van Stel et al. 2012; Swirasky and Ofir 2014).

The solo self-employed in our study expected to earn salaries similar to those of employed workers or what they could have earned as employed workers. Although they define themselves as business owners, their economic goals are not entrepreneurial and they use concepts from the world of employed workers: They want “to make a living,” and it’s very important to them to “earn a salary.” Two examples follow:

Shiran: It’s worthwhile if I make a profit of NIS 8000 per month for my economic stability, because I’m financially stressed. I just told my mother that I keep dreaming that I’m losing my teeth. I’m told that’s related to money.

Galit: I really don’t think about how to get more work or expand the business. I have a system that allows me to earn a salary every month, a permanent amount [from the family business account]. This works for me because financial stress is what motivates me best. I guess I don’t really want to expand because I don’t want to invest all of my efforts in the business.

The findings show that the solo self-employed describe their independence as a democratic space, without a hierarchy, in which several content fields are integrated, where one can sit in a coffee shop and work at the same time, where parenting is combined with work on a fundamental level—the key word is *integration* rather than *separation*. This is in contrast to common, popular images of “employed workers” among the upper-middle-class interviewees in our study, where separation and hierarchy between work and the rest of life’s aspects are emphasized, in addition to competitiveness, ambition, and the desire for prestige (financial and social) (Williams 2000). The findings also show that the solo self-employed do not scorn employed workers themselves but are opposed to the widespread self-conception of employed workers.

Boundary-work versus “businesspeople”: commercialism, anticommercialism, and personal fit

Together with the boundary-work in which solo self-employed engage as opposed to employed workers, they also engage in boundary-work in opposition to another group—entrepreneurs and businesspeople. Most of the interviewees perceive themselves as business owners, and the word *business* came up numerous times during the interviews, but directly after, the interviewees often apologized, quickly explaining that even though they have a business, they are not businesspeople and did not want to be perceived as such.

Solo self-employed boundary-work contrary to entrepreneurs and businesspeople was carried out in three dimensions: growth versus satisfaction, marketability versus professionalism, and greed versus balance. This boundary-work, in contrast to the previous form, takes place in contrast to an unfamiliar, almost imaginary self. Neither they nor their life partners have experience as entrepreneurs, and while they are familiar with this world, they have no direct experience of it, as they do with being employed workers. In this form of boundary-work, the “self-employed” category, which had a certain presence in the boundary-work related to employed workers, was abandoned in order to discuss the “self.”

Growth versus satisfaction—“I don’t need the headache”

Twenty-five of 30 of the interviewees expressed a clear lack of desire to expand their businesses or employ other workers, while four of them said they weren’t sure about the option of hiring part-time help to perform technical tasks only. The subject of hiring other workers didn’t come up naturally in most of the interviews but was asked as a direct question. Expressions used in response to this question included “a headache,” “stress,” and “a nightmare,” negative adjectives expressing interviewees’ attitudes about growth. On the other hand, the common expressions used to describe the self, included “it’s enough for me,” “freedom,” and “life.” The interviewees seem to be reasonably satisfied with themselves. They are satisfied with having enough work to get by but don’t necessarily want more than that. They simply want to be able to live a certain kind of life and not necessarily be extraordinarily successful from a financial point of view. This feeling is described by Lior:

I’m a business, but still, I don’t want to grow because I have enough. Enough to manage my life the way I want to ... I don’t need the headache of employing other people.

The determined attitude of the solo self-employed against growing and expanding the business doesn’t fit the expected business profile and makes them feel they need to defend their attitudes and choices. Naomi talks about pressure from her husband to expand the business and her opposition:

I don’t have any desire to expand. To start employing others. My husband and I argue about it a lot. Today I have lots of work; I’m busy all the time. But once you start employing others, you have a responsibility to this machine—the business. You need to feed the machine and I’m not interested in that. Even it means earning more money, well, I guess I don’t really have a passion for making money, I just don’t have it.

For Naomi, as for other interviewees, employing others is connected to a desire for money, shopping, and restaurants, which in her opinion is in conflict with being able to change, being spontaneous, and alternative.

Marketability versus authenticity—“I’m not good at it”

The solo self-employed know that marketing is essential, but their relationships with marketing ranged from complete avoidance to something they felt forced to do; they also identified it as the

main difficulty in being a solo self-employed. If the lack of desire to expand was perceived by most as a sort of accepted fact, here the boundary-work was a bit more stormy an issue. Marketing is perceived with an “it’s not me” attitude, as a loathed and artificial necessity, something done by “businesspeople,” who are into “the chase” and want to “sell themselves”:

Galit: The business angle has an especially annoying element about it—if I have to create a course, I have to do all the marketing and Facebook work myself, talk to people, phone them—all of which I hate.

Interviewer: How do you relate to this issue?

Galit: In a very negative way, it’s like saying: “Yes, come to the course; I’m an excellent teacher, and it’ll be like this and like that.” It’s exhausting; I don’t like to praise myself. I’m pretty introverted and don’t like talking about myself, so it’s a contradiction. Marketing, for me ... it’s an issue, the business world, in general, even my idea of what a business is, isn’t very business-like.

Galit defines herself as an introverted person who doesn’t like to talk about herself, a component that contradicts the marketing she does for her business. For her, talking about her business is experienced as talking about herself and her negative view of the business world. Dalia also uses the expression “businesspeople” in her boundary-work in regard to marketing, describing it as an experience that lacks authenticity:

I understand more and more that marketing requires contacts and I understand more and more that I hate mingling, and hate the entire process, and I’m not sure it’s really necessary. It just doesn’t suit me. On Facebook, etc., I do it because it creates a certain image, but in meetings with other businesspeople ... it’s just not my way of doing things. I feel uncomfortable. It makes me feel extremely embarrassed. I feel completely fake.

Meital and Yaron don’t talk about businesspeople in a direct way in their boundary-work; rather, they mention “people who are good at it” (marketing) and “I’m really not good at it”:

Meital: I’m really not good at marketing. It’s just not my thing. It’s not me. Some people are good at it. I’m not good at chasing anyone down. I always say—work comes to me; I don’t need to run after it.

Yaron: Just this past year (after 8 years of being self-employed), I made a website and joined Trip Advisor. I feel that I’m not good at it [marketing].

Greed versus balance

The boundary-work done by the solo self-employed, as opposed to entrepreneurs and businesspeople, is also carried out around the central currency in the world of work—money. Earning money is just as important to the solo self-employed as it is for employed workers, as previously described. However, having a lot of money is perceived by them as “greedy capitalism,” “unhealthy,” and being “part of the game,” whereas the really important thing, in their opinion, is living a balanced lifestyle. From this perspective, boundary-work doesn’t occur specifically opposite businesspeople, but rather opposite people for whom consumerism, branding, and marketing are core parts of their existence, characteristics often attributed to businesspeople.

Yonatan has been working for many years as a senior programmer and consultant and makes large sums of money, typical in his field. He works with large, wealthy financial corporations, in a very achievement-oriented environment:

I hate money. Really. I just don’t get it. That means I avoid making decisions about how to invest my money. I hate banks. The Western, capitalistic economy is greedy, and spoiled. I go and talk to the banks, who are my clients. If they knew what I really think of them, I doubt they would let me work with them. In general, all of this engineered food is a bad thing, because it creates friction and misleading social and economic conceptions among people who are chasing happiness ... they’re chasing paper.

It appears that the solo self-employed try to escape two well-known cultural scenarios and build new, independent, and alternative spaces for themselves. They try to leave all the control, narrowness, and compromise behind, along with the organizational politics related to being employed workers. At the same time, they also try to avoid the greed, burnout, and artificiality of the self they believe are characteristic of entrepreneurs and businesspeople. They don't describe themselves as searching for some middle ground between these two scenarios but are seeking something else, something different. Because of the absence of a strong category defining the independence of the solo self-employed, they undergo a process of trying to find new definitions and self-conceptualizations. The great similarity, across diverse professions, with which the solo self-employed speak about themselves and their work, teaches us about the existence of a distinct and unique self-concept that accompanies it. The rare use of "independent" hints at the fact that it doesn't reflect clear experiences about the self or professional demand when related to strong social categories (Wildhagen 2015).

Discussion: popular cultural scenarios and an alternative self

Our study findings show an ambiguous understanding of the "independent" category and a phenomenological lack regarding the solo self-employed category. The vagueness of the independent category is expressed by the many names and concepts used by the interviewees when talking about themselves and their work. This multiplicity, in turn, creates a difficulty related to identifying oneself with the category and in demanding rights in comparison to strong social categories. This vagueness, we claim, is a product of the lack of a strong cultural scenario (Swidler 2001) regarding independence among governmental authorities, among the popular media, and in academic research.

The similar descriptions by the interviewees about so many aspects of life and identity, across many professions, are a convincing-enough reason to group them together. These similarities were evident throughout all of the narratives: Most managed well as employed workers, and their motives for making the transition from being employed to becoming solo self-employed stemmed from similar themes. Most described the process as very slow and gradual. In addition, their descriptions show that they experienced being solo self-employed as a discovery that, for a while, was focused on attaining diversity, personal expression, recognition, and flexibility. All of them said they were neither employed workers nor businesspeople, but they did not clearly categorically define their occupational status. All had a very concrete occupational identity and said they loved their work. While some clearly defined themselves as having a "business," they had complex ways of relating to capitalistic businesses, including money and marketing. Most did not want to grow and expand, and success for them meant earning a salary similar to what they could potentially earn as employed workers.

The intensive boundary-work of the solo self-employed is carried out contrary to two strong and well-known occupational categories: employed workers and businesspeople. They are familiar with the former from their own previous experience, and the latter they know (or imagine) because of its dominance in popular fields. This boundary-work, which creates self-conceptions by defining what one is not ("not an employed worker"; "not a businessperson"), provides self-meaning in light of the categorical ambiguity related to being "independent" as well as the categorical weakness of being "solo self-employed."

The solo self-employed in our study—members of the mid-to-high socioeconomic bracket—don't talk about independence as something temporary until they find their ways into positions as employed workers. The differences between the solo self-employed and the employed worker aren't technical, although they are significant: Being self-employed allows for increased diversity, self-expression, daily freedom, and a more convenient family life. The earned monthly salary is replaced

by the experience of establishing a business and talking about it: a business that is built up slowly, in a way that suits the individual—a sort of other, alternative, tailor-made self.

In parallel with the solo self-employed boundary-work opposite employed workers, another type of boundary-work is carried out by this group in contrast to “businesspeople” and “entrepreneurs” in an attempt at self-identification: Most do not want to expand, tend to avoid marketing, and have a complex attitude toward money: Money isn’t the main driving force behind their work.

It is important to emphasize that all of our interviewees managed well in the world of employed workers, want their businesses to succeed, and have a need for recognition but not at the cost of sacrificing quality of life within either their careers or regarding money. The solo self-employed want to “have enough”; they strive to “be precise to themselves” and want to attain “employment intimacy” and a type of “tailor-made” “self-growth.” Not one of the interviewees defined him- or herself as a businessperson or entrepreneur, and they specifically said they were “different”—individuals seeking a professional solution that suited their “different” self-concepts in relation to the widespread cultural scenarios. This search for an alternative self is described by the solo self-employed as a result of examining different identity options—a long, careful, and gradual process.

In light of the preceding, we propose to interpret the solo self-employed experience in our study as an alternative form of self-expression in response to the popular cultural-occupational scenarios. According to the interviewees, being solo self-employed provides them with a unique alternative, which combines a professional-occupational identity and self-expression (or a personal self). The solo self-employed alternative self is expressed, *inter alia*, by (slow and gradual) resistance to the image of the ideal, bourgeois employed worker scenario, widespread in both their professional fields and daily lives (Stephens et al. 2014). The image of the bourgeois employed worker is described as being based on a strong capitalistic ethos, hyperindividualism, efficiency, competitiveness, the accumulation of resources (economic, cultural, and symbolic), and the existence of a work/private life hierarchy. The solo self-employed in our study want to lead a more fluid existence in which different aspects of life become integrated—the ability to work when it suits them, the easy merging of working and raising children (for both men and women), and an emphasis on a reasonable amount of free time. Two of the most interesting characteristics of this alternative self that surfaced in the study were “having enough” and “being precise to oneself.” Having enough relates to the level of resources (economic and cultural) that allows one to have a balanced lifestyle, including both one’s working life and one’s private life.

Self-accuracy refers to the way in which occupational identity also expresses the individual self. In this sense, our interviewees mobilize the psychological discourse to support the concept of the private self and to create an alternative to the dominant capitalist and neoliberal discourse. The psychological discourse, which emphasizes authenticity, self-realization (Rose 1996), and “self-accuracy” (in the terms of the interviewees), is actually described by them as a counterdiscourse (Foucault 2007) to the capitalist and neoliberal discourse, which distances the individual from his or her independence. The use of psychological discourse and the establishment of a professional and personal alternative through it helps interviewees experience themselves as “not too controlled” (and in the words of Foucault 2007:45, “not governed quite so much”) by the dominant discourses in the employment field and in everyday life. In this sense our interviewees do not experience the discursive alliance (Shoshana 2014) between the psychological discourse and the capitalist discourse as it is depicted by various scholars (Cushman 1995). The alliance between psychology and capitalism is mainly described as creating similar subjectivity that in turn maintains the hegemonic social orders. This is a subjectivity that gives preference to personal attributes over social ones, prefers a-politicism (Rose 1996), and is engaged in identifying entrepreneurial alternatives for self-realization and an experience of authenticity. This gap between the interpretation of the interviewers and the interpretation of the scholars reminds us once again of the importance of maintaining a distinction between the perspective of the researcher, or *etic*

interpretation, and the perspective of the subjects and subjective emic interpretation (see Barley and Kunda in 2004:23 in this regard).

To achieve a more thorough understanding of the self-concept and occupational experiences of the solo self-employed, our study encourages future studies to focus on four key domains:

First, our study focused on a specific group. Our participants were from the mid-to-high socioeconomic bracket and were educated secular Jews whose ages ranged from 29 to 45. There is no doubt that the total solo self-employed population includes other, less educated subjects from other socioeconomic brackets, such as cosmeticians, drivers, construction workers, electricians, and agriculturalists, among others, as well as minority groups such as Arabs (for whom the percentage of the self-employed is even higher). There are also additional subgroups of solo self-employed that were not included in the study: older self-employed individuals (age 45 and older) and individuals who are simultaneously employed and independent, in a purely “technical” manner, such as independent workers who work with one main client on an ongoing basis and submit an invoice at the end of every month.

Second, despite the statistics that show high percentages of failure among the solo self-employed, most of the solo self-employed in this study expressed optimism in relation to their independence. It seemed that these individuals are successful and manage to earn a salary similar to that of employed workers in the same professional fields. Additional studies about the solo self-employed should attempt to differentiate between those who manage to realize their solo self-employed identities over time and those who find it difficult. In this context, particular attention should be paid to the precarious nature of this form of employment of the self-employed and solo self-employed. The findings of this study did not allow us to dwell on this issue, since our interviewees did not talk about it and even reported economic success (or income that is sufficient for them). At the same time, many studies describe how self-employed workers report the absence of fair government laws, government disregard, and their anxieties about the future (Barley and Kunda 2004). It is clear to us that future research requires special attention to this issue, even among solo self-employed who describe economic satisfaction. It would be very interesting to find out how they deal with the precarious nature of their work.³

Third, our study findings encourage comparative gender research. All of the women in the study, mothers and nonmothers alike, discussed the link between their solo self-employed status and family lives as one of the motivating forces behind their decisions to become self-employed. The men in the study didn’t make this connection during the actual transition but only in retrospect as an important advantage they discovered afterward. It is possible that a study with a higher number of solo self-employed can teach us more about the subtler differences between men and women.

Fourth, it is important that future studies focus on governmental construction of solo self-employed categories. Israel’s ambiguous way of defining solo self-employed individuals raises uncertainties about the country’s involvement in further blurring the category. It is possible to research this subject, for example, by analyzing texts that address the self-employed and solo self-employed in various government institutions.

These research investigations may not only deconstruct the homogeneous nature of the solo self-employed category but also serve to transform it—along with its related occupational subcategories—into existential alternatives in relation to more popular occupational scenarios in our culture.

Author notes

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³We thank one of the anonymous reviewers for this remark.

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